

Put `std::monostate` in `<utility>`

- Document number: P0472R2
- Date: 2024-09-09
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Revision History

Revision 2

- Added *Alternatives* section, currently referring to `std::nullptr_t`.
- Proposed Wording - redone.

Revision 1

- Keep `std::monostate` in `<variant>` too, for backward compatibility.
- Added a use case (safe invocation utility) in the motivation section.
- Added backward compatibility section.
- Added proposed wording.
- Added co-author.

Revision 0 (2016)

- Original version.

Abstract

`std::monostate` is currently defined and available in the `<variant>` header, but its utility is not limited to `variants`. We propose adding `std::monostate` availability to `<utility>` to reduce artificial coupling of `std::monostate` clients to the `<variant>` header. We are not proposing removing `std::monostate` from `<variant>`, for backward compatibility.

Motivation

`std::monostate` is a class that has exactly one value. It is default constructible, copyable and supports all the comparison operations, or in other words it is a regular type. `std::monostate` is about as simple of a type as one could concoct. These properties turn out to be useful for writing template code.

The first use case is in testing. Does your custom `vector` or `set` make any undesirable assumptions about the types they are instantiated with? If they work properly with `std::monostate`, then probably not. `std::monostate` can be used in this way as a means to write simple test drivers.

The second use case occurs in more sophisticated template metaprogramming. The well known `std::future` class makes use of a "special" template parameter `void` to indicate that it carries no information aside from when the future is fulfilled. Using the `void` keyword to represent this situation carries a serious implementation burden due to its many strange properties. While this burden may not be a problem for standard library implementers, it would be nice to have a simpler option for the more common developer.

Another similar use case involves writing a safe invocation utility which executes a provided `std::invocable` and swallows all exceptions (via `catch(...)`). Such a utility would provide the returned value wrapped in either a `std::optional` or a `std::expected`, which would be returned as disengaged/unexpected in case the outcome of the invocation was an exception. This utility would also need to support callables returning `void`, which for ease of writing generic code we would want to share the same `std::optional/std::expected` representation. For this end `std::monostate` would be an ideal choice for value/expected type, as it is a regular type while at the same time cannot be mistakenly assigned or implicitly converted to any other useful type.

`std::monostate` is a much more natural way to represent "no information" than `void` is. It has exactly one value and is a regular type instead of a keyword. Consider how simple the following code is:

```
template<typename ExtraInformation = std::monostate>
class Data
{
    //...
    ExtraInformation m_extraInformation;
};
```

Here we have a `Data` template which optionally carries extra information. The use of `std::monostate` in this example makes it simple in both specification and implementation to represent `Data` objects that carry no additional information.

Alternatives

As has been pointed out on the reflector, there already exists a similar type - `std::nullptr_t`. Why wouldn't we settle for it as a proper general use substitute?

The reason is that misuses of `std::monostate` are much less likely. `std::nullptr_t` can be copied to any pointer type, and can be outputted by both `cstdio` and `iostream` families of facilities. `std::monostate` is ill-formed in any assignment as well as in streamed output, and is only well-formed with `cstdio` functions (with likely QoL warnings). This makes it a better match for a type that should represent nothingness, something that nothing useful can be done with.

Backward Compatibility

This is a library-only proposal, thus it has no impact on the language.

This is strictly an addition to the `<utility>` header. The `<variant>` header is not modified in any way per this proposal, thus requiring no change in existing codebases. Nor are any other parts of `<utility>` modified.

Proposed Wording

Add a new paragraph at the end of `[variant.monostate]`:

In addition to being available via inclusion of the `<variant>` header, the class `monostate` is available when the `<utility>` header is included.

Conclusion

`std::monostate` is a generally useful type and therefore belongs in a more appropriate header than `<variant>`. We are proposing adding it to `<utility>`, while preserving `<variant>` as is for backward compatibility.